

Geolocating Political Donations in Canada*

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1 Introduction

“Although political parties and candidates must disclose the names of their donors, use of those lists for any purpose is prohibited, so researchers cannot use them to identify the target population” (Garnett et al. 2022). However, Garnett (2024) uses to geolocate donors anyways. Further in the paper they say: “Using the disclosed postal code of donors paired with census data, Carmichael and Howe (2014) find that donors are more likely to live in wealthier neighborhoods. More recently, a pair of articles have analyzed Elections Canada’s administrative dataset, (which discloses the names of donors, the amounts they donated, and to whom) using predictive analytics to identify donor ethnicity (Besco and Tolley 2020) and gender (Tolley, Besco, and Sevi 2020)”. Very confusing.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Political Donation, Participation, and Representation

In Canada (and many other Western democratic nations) federal representation is fundamentally geographical: a Member of Parliament (MP) supposedly represents the aggregate views of their constituents, that is, everyone who lives within the boundaries of their riding. By voting during a general election, the citizens of a given electoral district increase the likelihood that their incumbent MP votes, acts, looks, and thinks how they want them to. Normatively, the

*Code and data are available at: <https://github.com/bennypk1/geolocating-political-donations>.

stratification of the population across spatial lines efficiently groups similar citizens, paired with the equal weight of each vote ultimately result in an ideal representative democracy ; there is high congruence between what a legislator does, and what their constituents want (Bednar, 2011).

Beyond voting, individual citizens often seek to increase their local representation by volunteering at a local electoral district association (EDA), advocating for their preferred party online, or financially supporting a candidate’s campaign (Bednar, 2011 ; Baker et al., 2016 ; Garnett et al., 2024). Since these necessitate (1) more resources (e.g. time, effort, or money), (2) indicate greater political interest, and (3) often have larger impacts on electoral outcomes relative to voting, political scientists classically argue that these constitute “higher forms” of political participation (Bednar, 2011).

Among these, donations stand out as a useful unit for understanding the motivations behind interested citizens and for assessing whether higher forms of political participation distort the (ideally) dyadic relationship between constituents and their MP. Here, we discuss two reasons why. First, donations are spatiotemporally unconstrained, offering insight into exactly when and where citizens seek representation (Gimpel et al., 2008 ; Garnett, 2024). While the voter can only seek representation within their district and during an election cycle, the donor can legally contribute to various political entities, whenever, and as often as they want, subject to annual and per-election limits (Gimpel et al., 2008 ; Elections Canada, 2026). Second, donations are the primary means by which individuals extend their representation beyond district borders (termed “surrogate” representation by Gimpel et al., 2008). Enabled by modern digital communication, individuals are increasingly motivated to finance national parties, or non-local candidates, in an attempt to be represented on ideological, partisan, or identity-based grounds (Gimpel et al., 2008). For example, a Green-party partisan may realize their local candidate will lose, and are perfectly content funding another Green candidate in a closer race somewhere else. Similarly, a Black candidate may appeal to Black donors across the country seeking identity-based representation. Given that individual donors are the presently largest source of campaign funding (Carmichael & Howe, 2014 ; Garnett, 2024), high rates of out-of-district donation are of particular concern, since they risk shifting the effective representational structure away from one-Legislator-one-district and towards one-Legislator-one-donor base.

2.2 Political Donations in the Canadian Context: What has been done

In this section we briefly review relevant, existing work on Canadian political donations to hopefully provide context for our work.

Much research has been done to determine the socio-demographic characteristics of donors and candidates in Canada. Most notably, Garnett analyzed candidate-bound donations during the 2015, 2019, and 2021 general elections, finding that donors are much more likely to originate from older, wealthier, and better-educated districts (Carmichael & Howe, 2014 ; Garnett, 2024). From 2004 to 2015, federal donation amount increased, particularly in Western Canada (McMahon & Wolfe, 2015). Sevi compiled a dataset of demographic variables for all candidates who ran between 1867 to 2019, revealing, for example, that the share of women incumbents has increased (Sevi, 2021).

Garnett et al. propose that donors donate for two reasons: political (i.e. for representational gain) and transactional (Garnett et al., 2022). They find that political motivations are more prevalent overall, but especially among older and affluent donors who contributed larger sums (Garnett et al., 2022). Transactional donations were more likely at the local level, while political donations were more likely at the national level (Garnett et al., 2022).

When analyzing donor-recipient relationships, Canadian research has found that donors tend to donate more to candidates that they share aspects of their identity with (Tolley et al., 2022 ; Besco & Tolley, 2022). Tolley et al. found that women donors are more likely to donate to women candidates (Tolley et al., 2022), and Besco & Tolley found high rates of co-ethnic donation, particularly among South Asian donors (Besco & Tolley, 2022). More generally, South Asian political participation appears to be particularly heightened in Canada, relative to other ethnocultural groups (see Garnett, 2024 and Bronsens, 2012 for even more findings). Together with previous findings on donor motivation, these results support the hypothesis that out-of-district donors in Canada are likely socially motivated, seeking individual-based representation.

Finally, some work has been done assessing the impacts of political donation on representation. Among incumbent Legislators, voting behaviour is seemingly independent of the composition of their donor base (Peoples & Gotari, 2008). However, an older study found that local campaign donations during the 1993 and 1997 elections meaningfully affected the amount of votes a candidate receives (Eagles, 2004).

2.3 American Out-of-District Donations to U.S. Congressional Representatives

We were unable to find a rigorous treatment of out-of-district donations during Canadian federal elections. By contrast, American scholars have explicitly addressed out-of-district donations and their impacts on legislative representation, catalyzed primarily by Gimpel et al.’s extensive treatment of individual out-of-district donations during 4 Congressional elections from 1994 – 2004 (Gimpel et al., 2008). They propose the existence of “donor districts” ; a small set of older, wealthy, well-educated, and urban districts wherein a large majority of out-of-district donations originate, destined to Republican and Democrat candidates alike (Gimpel et al., 2008 ; Bramlett et al., 2011). We should notice that these socio-economic factors are the same drivers of donor output in general across North America (Gimpel et al., 2006 ; Garnett, 2024). Over this time period, they also observed an increase in the proportion of non-local donations received by the average candidate, from around 50% in 1994 to nearly 70% in 2004 (Gimpel et al., 2008). More recent studies suggest that this and similar trends have continued past 2004 (Bramlett et al., 2011 ; Baker, 2016 ; Canes-Wrone & Miller, 2022). Driven by the observation that the “closeness” of local races strongly predicted which districts received these non-local donations, Gimpel et al. argue that gaining a partisan advantage (and not seeking ideological or identity-based representation) is the primary motivation behind non-local donations (Gimpel et al., 2008).

Follow-up American research has found that out-of-district campaign contributions affects the voting behaviour of Congressional representatives, thereby distorting the supposedly-dyadic relationship between a representative and their district. A study of the 2006-2010 Congressional elections revealed that the average House representative becomes less responsive to their constituencies’ ideological preferences with increasing out-of-district public funding (Baker, 2016). Canes-Wrone & Miller further explore the 2006-2016 Congressional elections to show that House voting behaviour is indeed associated with the preferences of their nation donor base (Canes-Wrone & Miller, 2021), contrasted against research finding that political action committees (U.S. equivalents to EDAs) do not affect roll call behaviour (Ansolabehere et al., 2011). Yet another study on Senatorial elections emphasizes the rivalrous relationship between constituents and out-of-district donors, experimentally showing that constituents who learned about outside donation expected their Senators to be less loyal to local interests (Nathan et al., 2024). More generally, longitudinal analyses of out-of-state (and therefore out-of-district donations) during Senate elections echo many House findings (Sievert & Mathiasen, 2023 ;

Jacobs & Imboywa, 2024 ; Keena, 2024).

To an even greater extent than in Canada, individual donors are the primary source of funding for both U.S. campaigns and U.S. congressmen (Gimpel et al., 2008 ; Baker 2016). This fact, paired with the many known effects of out-of-district donors on campaigns and representatives discussed above paint the picture that representatives “represent” little more than the whims of their national donor base.

3 Data

4 Appendix A: Background on Federal Donation Limits